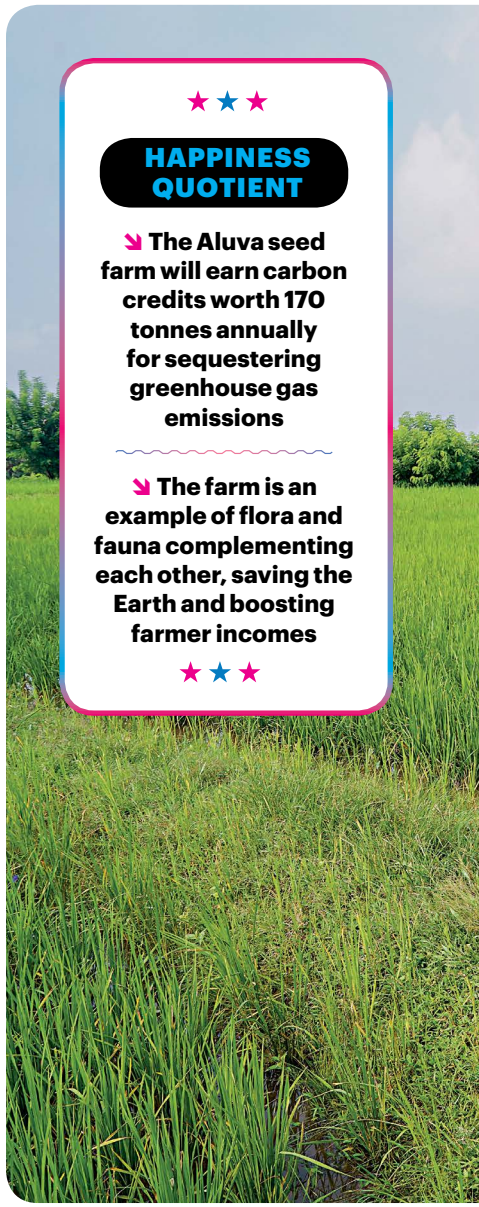
THE HAPPINESS ISSUE

THE SEEDS OF HOPE

India's **first carbon-neutral organic seed farm** in Kerala's Aluva is a role model for farmers in a world threatened by global warming

By **JEEMON JACOB** *in Kochi*



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HAPPINESS QUOTIENT

The Aluva seed farm will earn carbon credits worth 170 tonnes annually for sequestering greenhouse gas emissions

The farm is an example of flora and fauna complementing each other, saving the Earth and boosting farmer incomes

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A 120-year-old seed farm on the banks of the Periyar river has become a "role model for survival" at a time when climate change and the perils of global warming are on everyone's minds. The 5.32 hectares of land in Aluva in the suburbs of Kochi became India's first carbon-neutral organic seed farm in December 2022. 'Carbon-neutral' indicates that the farm does not contribute to greenhouse gas emissions and that whatever is produced is absorbed by the soil and plants here.

The Kerala Agricultural University's College of Climate Change and Environmental Science found that the farm on Thuruth island emitted 43 tonnes of carbon but was 'storing' 213 tonnes. This meant that the seed farm was not just carbon-neutral, but also has 170 tonnes of carbon credits. "We have been following organic modules since 2012, while also sensitising the farmers and other locals about the need to create agricultural spaces for reducing greenhouse gas emissions," says assistant director, agriculture department, Lissymol J. Vadakkoot, who has been heading the seed farm for the past seven years.

The success has encouraged the state agriculture department to initiate more such spaces in the state. Some 13 government seed farms across the state are now implementing the Aluva model to attain carbon-neutral status. Many farms in the tribal villages in the Wayanad hills are also trying for certification by competent bodies.